

Liberius Dossier 355

Liberius to the exiled confessors — Quamuis sub imagine pacis (GENUINE; A.D. 355; CSEL 65, Ser. B VII 1–2, pp. 164–166)

VII. 1. Now Liberius, before he went into exile, wrote this uniform letter to the confessors, that is, to Eusebius, Dionysius and Lucifer, who had been placed in exile.

2. 1. Although, under the appearance of peace, the enemy of the human race seems to have raged the more violently against the members of the Church, yet you — priests most acceptable to God — an outstanding and singular faith has both shown to be approved in God's sight here and now, and has already marked out as martyrs for the glory to come. With what heralding of praise, then, with what exultation of voice I might set forth the merits of your virtue, placed as I am between grief at your absence and joy at your glory, I simply cannot discover — except that I know I offer you here a more convincing consolation, if you believe that I have been thrust into exile together with you. In short, I am grieved enough that I am left still hanging in expectation, because a harsher necessity meanwhile withdraws me from your fellowship. For I had wished, most devoted brothers, to be spent first on behalf of you all, so that through me your love might the more attain an example of glory. But let this be the palm of your merits — that you should come first, by your perseverance in the faith, to the illustrious glory of confession. I ask your love, therefore, to believe me present with you, and so to feel by that affection that I am not absent, and to understand that I grieve enough that I am for the time being separated from your fellowship. And how great a glory you have attained you can better know from this: that whereas those who were crowned in persecution could feel only the bloody swords of the persecutor, you, God's soldiers devoted in all things, having found even false brethren for enemies, carried off the victory over the faithless; and in proportion as their violence could grow in the world, in that same measure rewards of praise are found to be conferred on the priests. Be therefore secure concerning the heavenly promise.

2. And because you have been made nearer to God, lift me up by your prayers to the Lord — me, your fellow-priest, God's servant — that the assaults coming upon me, which from day to day, as they are announced, inflict graver wounds, I may be able to bear tolerably; that, with faith inviolate and the standing of the catholic Church preserved, the Lord may deign to make me your equal. And because I long to know more faithfully what was done in that very engagement, I beseech your holiness: deign to make it all known to me faithfully by letter, so that either my very spirit, which is tortured by conflicting rumours, or the strength of my body itself, which is already worn thin, may find some further support from your encouragement. *And in another hand:* May God keep you unharmed, my lord brothers.

Two fragments of resistance — Nolo te (to Caecilianus) and Inter haec (to Ossius) (GENUINE; 353/4; pp. 166–167)

3. Likewise Liberius, before he went into exile, wrote concerning Vincentius of Capua to Caecilianus, bishop of Spolegium:

4. (3) I do not wish the deed of Vincentius to call you back from the intention of a good work, dearest brother.

5. And to Ossius he speaks thus concerning the ruin of Vincentius:

6. Meanwhile — since I ought in nothing to pass over your conscience — many fellow-bishops from Italy came together, who together with me had entreated the most religious emperor Constantius to command, as had once seemed good to him himself, that a council be gathered at Aquileia. I inform your holiness that Vincentius of Capua, together with Marcellus, likewise a bishop from Campania, undertook our legation. And because I had great hope of him — that he would both hold the case excellently and had often sat as judge in the same cause together with your holiness — I had believed that the whole right of the Gospel, or of the legation, could be preserved. Not only did he obtain nothing, but he himself was even led into that same dissembling. After his deed, stricken with a twofold grief, I resolved that I must rather die for God, than seem to be at the last an informer, or to lend consent to sentences against the Gospel.

The narrative hinge, and Feder's rubric: EPISTULAE DUBIAE (p. 168)

7. (4) After all these things which Liberius had either done or promised, once sent into exile he brought them all to nothing, writing to the prevaricating Arian heretics who had unjustly passed sentence against the holy and orthodox bishop Athanasius.

Doubtful letters. (*Feder's rubric.*) (*Apparatus at this hinge — see the end-section: after deduxit the H² corrector inserts nam tribulationum tedio fatigatus scribit [“worn out by the weariness of his tribulations, he writes”]; after sententiam the FH¹H²m1 add istam, and H²m2H³H⁴ add ut exilio absolueretur et hereticae prauitati suum accomodaret assensum [“so that he might be released from exile and accommodate his assent to the heretical depravity”] — the transmission simultaneously softening and sharpening the charge.*)

First ‘fall’ letter — Pro deifico timore, to the Eastern bishops (STATUS: DUBIA; pp. 168–170)

8. To his most beloved brothers, the Eastern presbyters and fellow-bishops, Liberius greeting.

1 (5). By reason of godly fear your holy faith is known to God {and} to men of good will. As the Law says: *judge justly, ye sons of men* — I did not defend Athanasius; but, because Julius, bishop of blessed memory, my predecessor, had received him, I was afraid lest perhaps I might in some way be judged a prevaricator. 2 But when I learned —

when it pleased God — that you had justly condemned him, I promptly lent my consent to your sentences. Letters likewise concerning his name, that is, concerning his condemnation, I gave to our brother Fortunatianus to be carried to the emperor Constantius. And so, Athanasius having been removed from the communion of us all, whose letters too are not to be received by me, I declare that I hold peace with you all and with all the Eastern bishops, and throughout all the provinces peace and unanimity.

2 (6). For that you may know more truly that I profess the true faith through this my letter: since our common lord and brother Demophilus has deigned, of his benevolence, to set forth your catholic faith — which was treated, expounded and accepted at Sirmium by many of our brothers and fellow-bishops [*† this is the Arian perfidy; this I have marked; not an apostate — Liberius (what follows)*] **[[ANATHEMA ①]]** — by all who were present, this I have received with a willing mind [*† holy Hilary says anathema to him: † anathema pronounced upon you by me, Liberius, and upon your associates*] **[[ANATHEMA ②]]**; in nothing did I contradict; I accommodated my consent; this I follow, this is held by me. [*again anathema to you, and a third time, Liberius the prevaricator*] **[[ANATHEMA ③]]**. I have surely thought it right to ask your holiness — since you now perceive that in all things I am in agreement with you — to deign to labour by common counsel and zeal, that I may be released from exile and return to the see which has been divinely entrusted to me.

9. (7) Now the perfidy drawn up at Sirmium, which Liberius calls catholic, expounded to him by Demophilus — these are they who composed it: Narcissus, Theodorus, Basilus, Eudoxius, Demophilus, Cecropius, Silvanus, Ursacius, Valens, Evagrius, Irenaeus, Exuperantius, Terentianus, Bassus, Gaudentius, Macedonius, Marcus, Acacius, Julius, Surinus, Simplicius and Junior [*to be looked into — all heretics*] **[[ANATHEMA ④]]**.

Second ‘fall’ letter — Quia scio, to Ursacius, Valens and Germinius (DUBIA; pp. 170–172)

10. LIKEWISE LIBERIUS, FROM EXILE, TO URSACIUS, VALENS AND GERMINIUS.

1 (8). Because I know that you are sons of peace, and love also the concord and unanimity of the catholic Church, therefore — not driven by any necessity, I say it with God as witness, but for the good of the peace and concord which is to be preferred to martyrdom — by this letter I address you, my lord dearest brothers. **2** Let your prudence therefore know that Athanasius, who was bishop of the church of Alexandria, (has been condemned by me), before (I wrote) to the court of the holy emperor according to the letters of the Eastern bishops, (and) that he has been separated from the communion of the Roman church, as the whole presbytery of the Roman church is witness. This alone was the reason why I seemed rather late to send letters about his name to our brothers and fellow-bishops the Easterns: that my legates, whom I had directed from the city of Rome to the court, or the bishops who had been deported, might themselves also, together with them, if it could be done, be recalled from exile.

2 (9). And this too I wish you to know: that I asked our brother Fortunatianus to (convey) my letters to the most clement emperor, (which I made to the Eastern bishops, that they too might know that I have been separated, together with them, from the communion of Athanasius. These, I believe, his piety will receive gladly for the good of peace; a copy of them I have also directed to Hilary, the emperor’s faithful eunuch. Let your charity perceive that I have done these things with a kindly and innocent mind. Wherefore by this

my letter I address you, and adjure you by God almighty and Christ Jesus his Son, our God and Lord, that you deign to go to the most clement emperor) Constantius Augustus and to petition that, for the good of the peace and concord in which his piety ever rejoices, he may command me to return to the church divinely handed over to me, so that in his times the Roman church may suffer no tribulation. And you ought to know, dearest brothers, with a fair and simple mind, from this my letter, that I hold peace with you all, the bishops of the catholic Church. For you will win yourselves great consolation on the day of recompense, if through you the peace of the Roman church shall have been restored. I wish you also to know, through you, that our brothers and fellow-bishops Epictetus and Auxentius have peace and ecclesiastical communion with me; and these, I believe, will receive this gladly. But whoever shall dissent from our peace and concord, which — God willing — has been made firm throughout the whole earth, let him know that he is separated from our communion. [*anathema pronounced by me upon the prevaricator, along with the Arians*] [ANATHEMA ⑤].

Third ‘fall’ letter — Non doceo, to Vincentius (DUBIA; pp. 172–173)

11. LIKEWISE LIBERIUS, FROM EXILE, TO VINCENTIUS.

1 (10). I do not teach, but I admonish your holy mind, dearest brother, because evil conversations corrupt good morals. The snares of evil men are well known to you — whence I have come to this hardship; and pray that the Lord may grant endurance. My most beloved son Urbicus the deacon, whom I seemed to have as a consolation, has been taken from me by Venerius, an *agens in rebus*.

2 (11). (But) to your holiness I have thought it should be signified that I have withdrawn from that contention over the name of Athanasius and have sent letters to our brothers and fellow- bishops the Easterns about his name. Therefore, since — God willing — peace is everywhere ours, you will deign to convene all the bishops of Campania and to make these things known to them. From their number, together with your letter, write concerning our unanimity and peace to the most clement emperor, so that I too may be freed from my sorrow. *And in his own hand:* May God keep you unharmed, brother. *Likewise in his own hand a page written out:* With all the Eastern bishops we have peace, and with you. I have absolved myself before God. You shall see to it: if you should wish me to fail in exile, God will be judge between me and you.

The Council of Serdica to Pope Julius — to the head, that is, to the see of Peter (GENUINE; c. 343; Ser. B II 2, pp. 126–127)

2. HERE BEGINS THE COPY OF THE LETTER MADE TO JULIUS, BISHOP OF THE CITY OF ROME, DIRECTED TO BISHOP JULIUS BY THE SYNOD.

1 (9). What we have always believed, we hold even now; for experience proves and confirms what each man has heard by report. For it is true, what the most blessed teacher of the nations, the apostle Paul, said of himself: (since you seek a proof of him who speaks in me, Christ) — although indeed, because the Lord Christ dwelt in him, it cannot be doubted that the Spirit spoke through his soul and made the instrument of his body resound. And so you too, most beloved brother, separated in body, were present in a

concordant mind and will; and the excuse of your absence was both honourable and necessary, lest either schismatic wolves should commit theft and snatch by ambush, or heretical dogs, roused by rabid frenzy, should bark in madness, or at any rate the serpent, the devil, should pour out the venom of blasphemies. For this will be seen to be best and most exceedingly fitting: that the Lord's priests should refer, from each and every province, to the head — that is, to the see of the apostle Peter.

The independent channel — the Disputatio of Constantius and Liberius, *Historia tripartita* V.17 (CSEL 71, pp. 237–241)

[[p. 237]] THEODORET. 17. 1. For my part I wish to relate the dialogue held for the truth against Constantius by Liberius, in every way most renowned, since it was written down by faithful men of that time. For he governed the Roman church after Julius, the successor of Silvester.

DISPUTATION OF THE EMPEROR CONSTANTIUS AND LIBERIUS, ROMAN PONTIFF.

2. The emperor Constantius said: 'We — both because you are a Christian and are bishop of our city — have judged it fitting to summon you and admonish you not to delay renouncing the communion of the most wicked Athanasius, held fast by ineffable pride. For the whole world has approved that this be well done, and by a synodal sentence has decreed him an alien from ecclesiastical communion.'

3. Bishop Liberius said: 'O emperor, ecclesiastical judgments ought to be delivered with the utmost justice. Wherefore, if it seem good to your piety, order a hearing to be established; and if Athanasius appears worthy of condemnation, then, according to the form of ecclesiastical procedure, a fitting sentence is pronounced against him. For it is not possible to condemn a man about whom nothing has been examined.'

4. The emperor Constantius said: 'The whole world has adjudged his crimes; but he, as from the beginning, mocks the time.'

[[p. 238]] 5. Bishop Liberius said: 'Whoever subscribed did not themselves see what was done; but for the sake of glory and out of fear, and lest they suffer insults from you, they acquiesced.'

6. The emperor said: 'What is this glory and fear and insults?'

7. Liberius said: 'Whoever do not love the glory of God prefer your gifts. Him, therefore, whom these men did not see, they adjudged without examining — which is alien to Christianity.'

8. The emperor said: 'He was assuredly condemned to his face in the council of Tyre, and in the council all the bishops of the whole world alike decreed against him.'

9. Liberius said: 'That man was never judged in his own presence. For whoever then assembled and condemned him pronounced sentence after Athanasius had withdrawn from the tribunal.'

10. Eusebius the eunuch said: 'In the council of Nicaea he was proved an alien from the catholic faith.'

11. Liberius said: ‘Only five judged, of those who came with him by ship to the Mareotis, whom they sent for his accusation, to draw up proceedings against him. Of these, then, who were sent out, two are dead, Theognius and Theodorus; but the remaining three are alive, that is, Maris, Valens and Ursacius. By these men who were sent, a synod was held at Serdica for this cause. And they in the synod presented petitions asking pardon, because in the Mareotis they had, by calumny and from one side only, drawn up proceedings against Athanasius. Their petitions we now have in hand. [[p. 239]] To which of these does it befit us to give credence and communion, emperor — to those who first condemned him and afterward begged pardon, or to those who still strive to press this accusation?’

12. Bishop Epictetus said: ‘O emperor, he is making his speech today not for the cause of faith nor of ecclesiastical judgments, but that he may boast before the senators established in the city of Rome, as though he had overcome the prince.’

13. The emperor said to Liberius: ‘What fraction are you of the whole world, that you alone champion a most abominable man and dissolve the peace of the world and of the Church?’

14. Liberius said: ‘It is not because I am alone that the cause of faith is lessened. For in antiquity too only three were found resisting the king’s command.’

15. Eusebius the eunuch said: ‘Have you made our emperor a Nebuchadnezzar?’

16. Liberius said: ‘No. But is a man to be adjudged so irrationally who has not been examined? This I ask first: that a general subscription be brought forth confirming the faith set out at Nicaea; so that thus, our brothers being recalled from exile and restored to their own places, if those who breed disturbances for the churches shall be seen to consent to the apostolic faith, then all assembling at Alexandria — where both the accused and the accusers and their defender are — having examined the cause, we may be able to pronounce sentence.’

17. Bishop Epictetus said: ‘But the public post does not suffice for the conveyance of the bishops.’

18. Liberius said: ‘Ecclesiastical causes have no need [[p. 240]] of the public post. For the churches suffice to bring their own bishops as far as the sea.’

19. The emperor said: ‘What things have long since received their settled form cannot be undone; for the sentence of very many bishops ought to prevail. You alone are the one who defends the friendships of that criminal.’

20. Liberius said: ‘Emperor, we have never heard of a judge, in the absence of the accused, setting forth his crimes — unless because these hatreds appear to be personal.’

21. The emperor said: ‘He has indeed harmed all in the communion, yet none so much as me. For when the destruction of my elder brother did not satisfy him, he did not cease frequently to drive even Constans, of blessed memory, into enmities against me, until we, restrained by the greater gentleness, tempered the impulses of the one driving him on. And so I have no victory — neither against Magnentius nor against Silvanus — unless I shall have expelled that wicked man from ecclesiastical affairs.’

22. Liberius said: ‘Do not avenge your enmities through bishops; for the hands of churchmen ought to be free for sanctifying. Wherefore, if it seem good to you, order the priests to be summoned to their own places; and if they appear to be in concord with him

whom we for the present defend according to the orthodox faith established in the Nicene synod, then, assembling, they will provide for the peace of the world, so that a man who has not sinned may not be unjustly condemned.'

23. The emperor said: 'One thing only is sought: for I wish to send you back to Rome, embracing the ecclesiastical communion; and therefore be reconciled to peace and, subscribing, return to Rome.'

[[p. 241]] **24.** Liberius said: 'At Rome I have already said farewell to the brethren; for the sanctions of the Church are greater than dwelling in the city of Rome.'

25. The emperor said: 'You have, then, the space of three days for deliberation; if you are willing to subscribe, return to Rome; or else consider to what place you wish to be deported.'

26. Liberius said: 'The space of three days can in no way change my reasoning. Wherefore, send me where you will.'

27. But the emperor, after two days, Liberius having been examined and in no way recalled from his purpose, ordered him to be deported into exile at Beroea **28.** in Thrace. As Liberius was departing, the emperor assigned five hundred solidi for expenses. Then Liberius said to the man who brought them: 'Go, give them to the emperor; for he needs them **29.** to pay out to his soldiers.' Likewise the Augusta sent him as much. Liberius said: 'Give these back to the emperor; for he needs them for the expenses of his soldiers. But if the emperor has no need of them, let him give them to Auxentius and Epictetus; for they have need of them.' **30.** And when he had taken nothing from them, Eusebius the eunuch offered him other solidi. To whom Liberius said: 'You have laid waste the churches of the whole world, and do you bring these to me as to one condemned? Go, be first instructed to be a Christian.' These things done, after three days, taking nothing, he was sent into exile.